

Leaning on L^AT_EX

Most people format documents interactively. This article is for those who believe that content is king and that formatting is a necessary distraction—to learn why L^AT_EX is ideal for them.



How do you produce formatted, publication-quality material? Most people, when asked this question, would say they format their reports or articles as they write them. They might also tell you that they start with a template where strict standards are expected.

Such work habits appear to stand by us solidly when the volume of work does not exceed tens of pages. The moment the task at hand becomes book-sized, so to speak, you begin to wonder whether the formatting is a distraction in the process of content creation. Add a few mathematical expressions with special symbols, and you begin praying for a ‘procedural’ approach that will let you push your content through a typesetting pipeline that will produce professional quality, publisher-ready material.

This is where typesetting technology like TEX (pronounced ‘tech’) created by the iconic D E Knuth comes in. It lets you focus on your content rather than mousing around the formatting toolbar. It is also more precise than

any conventional word processor. Since the typesetting information is embedded as a mark-up, you can typeset your content as you type. L^AT_EX, which is a dialect of TEX developed by Leslie Lamport, is a What-You-Mean-Is-What-You-Get environment.

L^AT_EX, along with associated tools such as pdf_latex, gets installed by default for most distributions.

Your splash pool

A good learning environment is a L^AT_EX editor like Gummi. It lets you type in the left pane and shows a preview in the right. Later, you can always graduate to a WYSIWYG environment like LyX but with the advantage of being familiar with the basic L^AT_EX mark-up.

Let’s use the common, straightforward work flow producing PDF out of our L^AT_EX mark-up. Gummi flags syntax errors immediately. However, if compilation from the .tex file to PDF does not proceed, you need to look at